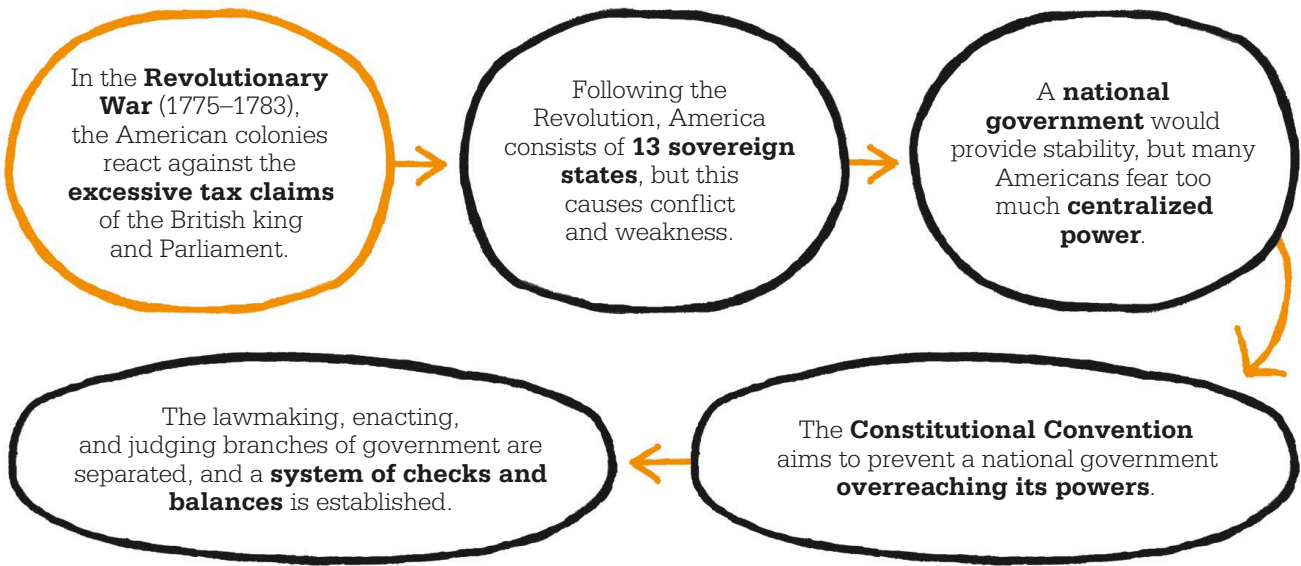


See also: Magna Carta 66–71 ■ The Glorious Revolution and the English Bill of Rights 102–103 ■ The Declaration of the Rights of Man 118–119 ■ The US Supreme Court and judicial review 124–129 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229



Like Rhode Island, other states feared that a federal government might overstep its powers and worried, too, about how they would be represented in Congress, the national legislature. Delegates from larger states wanted the number of representatives to reflect the size of their population; those from smaller states wanted equal representation.

The slavery question also came to the fore. Northern states, some of whom had already abolished slavery, strongly favored complete abolition, but states in the South were determined to ensure that slavery remained legal. So divisive was the issue that it was excluded from the Constitution and left to individual states to decide.

The Great Compromise

On the question of representation, the delegation from Virginia, which included Edmund Randolph and James Madison, set the agenda. The 15 resolutions of their Virginia Plan, which Randolph put to delegates,

outlined a wholly new structure of government based on a bicameral (two chamber) legislature, limited terms, and rotation of office, along with other bodies to act as checks and balances. The number of representatives from each state would depend on their economic power or their population.

While larger states agreed to the idea, small states did not. William Paterson of New Jersey countered with a plan to give each state an

equal voice in Congress. After a heated debate, delegates adopted a proposal from Roger Sherman of Connecticut to create two chambers—the Senate, where each state has equal representation, and the House of Representatives, in which representation is based on a state's population. This solution was dubbed the Great Compromise. Under the plan, each state would be able to appoint two senators to serve 6-year terms in the Senate. In the House of Representatives, seats would be held for 2 years, and the number each state had would be based on its population and reassessed every 10 years.

In a further debate, conference delegate James Wilson proposed that the president should be elected directly by the people. However, the majority of delegates decided that the general populace knew little about politicians outside their own states and would therefore be too ill-informed to make a valid choice. They agreed instead that the »

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Liberty, when it begins
to take root, is a plant
of rapid growth.
George Washington
1st US president (1789–1797)